

“LET SUCH AS ARE GOING TO **FIGHT FOR CHRISTIANITY** PUT THE FORM OF **THE CROSS** UPON THEIR GARMENTS **THAT THEY MAY OUTWARDLY DEMONSTRATE** THEIR DEVOTION TO THEIR **INWARD FAITH.**”

Pope Urban II, 1095

Hassan-i Sabbah leads initiations at Alamut, in an illustration from Marco Polo's 13th-century *Travels*.

IN 1090, A GROUP OF ISMAILI SHI'ITES BECAME INVOLVED IN A DISPUTE over the Fatimid succession in Cairo (see 901–10). Under the leadership of the charismatic **Hassan-i Sabbah**, this group recognized the claims of an infant called Nizar, and were therefore known as **Nizari Ismailis**. Forced to flee Cairo, Hassan led the Nizaris to his homeland in Persia where they captured a fortress known as **Alamut** in the mountainous region of Kazvin and made it the base of a de facto **Nizari kingdom**. Thus was born the group later known as the **Assassins**—a name derived from the word “hashashins,” a label applied by their enemies who claimed they used intoxicants such as hashish to brainwash devotees into blind obedience.

Alarmed by the advances of **Alfonso VI of Castile**, the **Abbadids** (see 1031) summoned the **Almoravids** from North Africa to defend against the Christian

13 THOUSAND THE NUMBER OF PLACES LISTED IN THE DOMESDAY BOOK

threat. Defeating Alfonso at Zallaka in 1086, they annexed most of Islamic Spain.

In 1085, **William the Conqueror** (see 1061) commissioned a survey of his new kingdom—known as the **Domesday Book**—probably to regulate military service and assess taxation opportunities.

IN 1092, CHINESE POLYMATH **SU SUNG** DESIGNED AND CONSTRUCTED A COSMIC ENGINE.

This mechanical astronomical clock was 30ft (9m) high, and was water-driven with an armillary sphere, which showed the position of celestial objects.

In 1094, a Castilian who had served both Christian and Islamic Masters, **Rodrigo Diaz de Vivar**, known by the Moors as **El Cid** (“the lord”), captured Valencia in eastern Spain and established himself as ruler.

At the **Council of Clermont** in 1095, Pope Urban, a French Cluniac (see 910), preached to an assembly of mainly Frankish clerics and nobles about Muslim “defilement” of the Holy Land, urging his audience to take up arms in a **holy war**. Urban had been entreated by the Byzantines for help against the Seljuks, and saw a way to channel the energies of European nobility away from constant infighting and toward a **Christian expansion** that would benefit the papacy. Fired by religious zeal and spurred by the promise of remission of sins, together with the prospect of winning booty, land, and control of the lucrative trade with the Orient, many nobles of France (formerly West Francia) and Lorraine joined, or “took the cross.”

Other nations were either in conflict with the papacy or indifferent, so the **First Crusade** was a largely French affair. Taking advantage of disarray in the Muslim world, three groups of Crusaders under Godfrey



Battle of the Crusades

This manuscript illustration shows Crusader knights joining battle with Saracens—the generic term used by Europeans to refer to their Muslim foes. Around 30,000 knights took part in the First Crusade.

and Baldwin of Bouillon, Count Raymond of Toulouse, and the Norman Bohemond of Otranto, took the Seljuk Rum capital of **Nicaea** in 1097, conquered **Edessa** in the same year, captured **Antioch** in 1098, and marched on **Jerusalem** in 1099. Godfrey was elected king of Jerusalem but took the title **Defender of the Holy Sepulchre**; his brother, Baldwin

became king the following year. Under the overlordship of the King of Jerusalem, the Crusaders established **four principal states**: the kingdom of Jerusalem, which thrived on trade mediated by the Italian trading powers; the county of Tripoli, set up by Raymond; the county of Edessa, established by Baldwin; and the principality of Antioch, set up by Bohemond.

75,000
SARACENS

15,000
CRUSADERS

The Siege of Antioch

Islamic forces at the Siege of Antioch outnumbered the Crusaders considerably. In fact Antioch fell only when a traitor opened a gate to a party of knights led by Bohemond of Otranto.



The Domesday Book

Nicknamed “Domesday” in reflection of the trepidation that the great undertaking inspired in the native English, William’s survey actually comprised two manuscripts; the Great and the Little Domesday.

